

SEXUALLY TRANSMITTED INFECTIONS

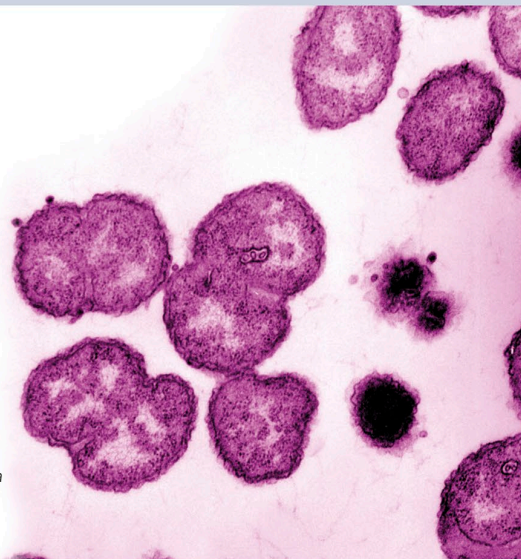
SEXUALLY TRANSMITTED INFECTIONS (STIs), ALSO KNOWN AS SEXUALLY TRANSMITTED DISEASES (STDs), ARE INFECTIONS THAT ARE PASSED FROM PERSON TO PERSON BY SEXUAL ACTIVITY. GENITAL, ANAL, AND ORAL SEX CAN ALL PASS ON AN INFECTION TO ANOTHER PERSON.

GONORRHOEA

Although gonorrhoea tends to be more prevalent among males, it can also affect women. The main sites of infection are the urethra and, in women, the cervix. The symptoms often do not appear, but if they do they commonly include a discharge of pus from the penis or vagina and pain on urination. Women may also experience lower abdominal pain and irregular vaginal bleeding. Occasionally, the infection spreads to other parts of the body, such as the joints (via the bloodstream). If the disease is left untreated, it can cause infertility in women.

GONORRHOEA BACTERIA

An electron micrograph of *Neisseria gonorrhoeae*, which is responsible for the STI gonorrhoea.



PELVIC INFLAMMATORY DISEASE (PID)

PID is a common cause of pelvic pain in young women; other possible symptoms are fever, heavy or prolonged periods, and pain during sexual intercourse. Sometimes, there are no symptoms. Usually, PID is the result of an STI such as chlamydial infection or gonorrhoea. Infection after childbirth or a pregnancy termination are also possible causes.

The inflammation starts in the vagina and spreads to the uterus and fallopian tubes. In severe cases, the ovaries are also infected. Left untreated, PID can lead to damage in the fallopian tubes, which may cause infertility and an increased risk of ectopic pregnancy (see p.302).

INFECTED PARTS

The fallopian tube and ovary on the right of the image are inflamed and swollen as a result of PID.

